

New Hope On CANCER

An explosion of research and treatment is changing the way cancer is treated, considerably boosting survival rates

By Damayanti Datta

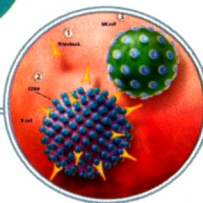
Wake up. Got out of bed. (Did not) drag a comb across my head... That's 37-year-old actor and model Lisa Ray's way of poking gentle fun at her incurable bone marrow myeloma and now shaven head ("I still have a ziplock bag of my hair"). That spirit has helped her find a new voice: her blog, *Yellow Diaries*, where she celebrates the colour of health and hope—yellow—keys in quick "yellow posts," sends "yellow wish" to browsers (5,00,000-plus) and describes the cut-

ting-edge stem cell transplant that she's just gone through ("Now I'm full of cheerful stem cells, like fields of sunflowers"). Diagnosed in June last year, Ray decided to give people an insight into her life and the new developments in cancer treatment. Poignant, often heart-wrenching and always full of optimism and courage, the daily chronicling of her journey into the unknown, in a way, encapsulates the story of cancer.

Is the glass half-empty or half-full on the cancer front? It's hard to tell where you stand in the war against the



The Promise of New Therapeutics



ROCKSTAR MOLECULES

New and exciting compounds that target pathways feeding cancer cells. They leave healthy cells unscathed, shrink tumours and cause fewer side-effects than chemo.



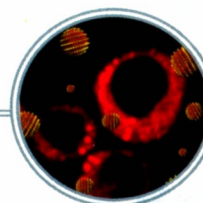
NEW-AGE BEAMERS

High-resolution scans and X-rays. Pinpoint cancers accurately, spare good cells. The latest are image-guided, can track patient movement, and work real-time.



SURGERY BY NATURE

Minimally invasive is the mantra. Focus is on preserving organs: breasts, voice box, jaws, limbs, etc. The latest is to mimic the body's own rhythm, antibodies, enzymes.



THE SMART AIMER

Targeted chemo or making anti-cancer drugs more tumour-specific. Aims the drug by placing "tags" to cancer cells. Point is to avoid damage to healthy tissue.



RUSH FOR TRIAL

Clinical trials drive cancer research today. The investment is enormous, although cancer is not the top killer. Over 800 compounds in the pipeline in the US.